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Handing Over the Spoon: A 3-Week Plan

From being fed to eating independently · Ages 2–5

Most toddlers can feed themselves with fingers by about 12 months and use a spoon well by around 2–3 years. Children fed for longer can learn quickly with a gradual handover.

Week 1

- ○ They eat the first few bites themselves, then you help
- ○ Offer easy finger foods: roti pieces, idli, cut fruit
- ○ Eat together at the table

Week 2

- ○ They feed half the meal
- ○ Teach tearing roti and scooping sabzi
- ○ A small spoon and a bowl with sides

Week 3

- ○ They feed most of the meal; you help only when asked
- ○ Praise effort: “You fed yourself the whole idli!”

Tips

- ○ Smaller portions, seconds allowed
- ○ A mat under the chair, a cloth within reach
- ○ Expect them to eat a little less at first
- ○ No screens at meals

When to check

If your child has trouble chewing or swallowing, or is losing weight, speak to your paediatrician.

SOURCES AND FURTHER READING

HealthyChildren.org (American Academy of Pediatrics): Feeding and nutrition for toddlers. · https://www.healthychildren.org/English/ages-stages/toddler/nutrition/

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